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BY THE EARLY 1960S, GE was receiving more speaking invitations for me from around the country than I could handle. And, although I was still saying the same things that I'd said for six years during the Eisenhower administration, I was suddenly being called a "right-wing extremist." The liberals just didn't like to hear someone say the growth of government ought to be restrained.

Some of the arrows I was firing into my old political camp seemed to be hitting home. After the Democrats won the White House in 1960, wherever I'd give a speech, in city after city, there'd be a cabinet member or other high official from the Kennedy administration who'd be giving a speech on the same day. In the television business, we used to call that "counter programming," an effort to knock out the competition with a rival show. I don't have any proof they planned it that way, but I don't think it was coincidental.

In 1962, there was a change in management at General Electric that brought an end to my satisfying eight-year relationship with the company. Ralph Cordiner was retiring and the new management asked me, in addition to continuing as host of the GE Theater, to go on the road and become a pitchman for General Electric products—in other words, become a salesman.

I told them that after developing such a following by speaking out about the issues I believed in, I wasn't going to go out and peddle toasters.

They insisted and when I still resisted, they canceled the show.

I realized that appearing on the General Electric Theater for so long probably hadn't endeared me to the people who